Akbar was able to bring up the question of wives with the Jesuits in another context, when discussing the practice of sati among Hindu women, when he said:

> Since you reckon the reverencing of women as part of your religion, and allow not more than one wife to a man, it would not be wonderful if such fidelity and life-sacrifice were found among your women. The extraordinary thing is that it occurs among those of the Brahman (Hindu) religion. There are numerous concubines, and many of them are neglected and unappreciated and spend their days unfructuously in the privy chamber of chastity, yet in spite of such bitterness of life they are flaming torches of love and fellowship.

Akbar had, of course, witnessed jauhar himself at Chittor when 300 women had turned to ashes and he would no doubt have heard more about sati from the Rajput women in his harem. If his Rajput noblemen were sharing with him their stories of bravery in battle then Akbar's Rajput wives would have had their own tales of exemplary behaviour to amaze him with. For the Charans did not confine their epic stories only to men. They also had to instruct Rajput women in their kulreet, the cultural norms which evolved over centuries to prop up the Rajput system. The implicit support of women was essential in ensuring that brave sons were raised to become equally brave husbands whose only destiny was often to embrace death. 'Oh friend! By taking a royal umbrella and chavar (ceremonial whisk) one cannot be called a Rajput nor by inheriting the title of Rajput', was one popular Charan refrain. 'It is only one who sacrifices himself for the benefit of the country who is a true Rajput'. In this way, the notion of sacrifice above all else, above personal happiness certainly, was subtly but inexorably passed on to women from a very young age. During the discussion with the Jesuits, Akbar was clearly admiring of the love the Hindu women seemed to demonstrate by performing sati, but Akbar's ideas on sati were to change drastically, as he became ever more compassionate and aware of the impossible and conflicting demands made on the women in this system. The visiting Jesuit priests the following year were to describe the abomination of the practice when they witnessed it, to which Akbar responded that such fortitude could only come from God: